

Butter Chicken (Murgh Makhani) (Variation 4)

Tags: chicken, indian, dinner, gluten-free | Prep: 30 min | Cook: 45 min | Serves: 3

Ingredients

- Marinade: 525 g boneless chicken thighs, 150 ml full-fat yoghurt, 1 tbsp lemon juice, 1 tsp turmeric, 1 tsp chilli powder, 1 tsp garam masala, 1 tsp cumin, 1 tsp coriander, 1 tsp salt
- Sauce: 2.2 tbsp butter, 1 large onion diced, 5 garlic cloves, 2 tsp fresh ginger, 1 tsp turmeric, 2 tsp paprika, 1 tsp garam masala, 1 tsp ground coriander, 1/2 tsp chilli powder, 1 can (400 g) crushed tomatoes, 150 ml heavy cream, 2 tsp sugar, Salt to taste
- fresh basil and steamed basmati rice or naan to serve

Method

1. Combine all marinade ingredients with chicken. Mix well, cover, and refrigerate for at least 2 hours (overnight is better).
2. Cook marinated chicken: either grill in a very hot pan until charred in spots, or roast at 220 °C for 20 minutes. Set aside.
3. Melt butter in a large saucepan over medium heat. Cook onion for 8 minutes until golden.
4. Add garlic and ginger. Cook 2 minutes.
5. Add all dry spices and cook for 1 minute until fragrant.
6. Add crushed tomatoes. Simmer for 15 minutes until oil separates and floats on top.
7. Blend the sauce completely smooth using an immersion blender.
8. Return sauce to heat. Add cooked chicken, cream, and sugar. Simmer for 10 minutes.
9. Taste and adjust salt. The sauce should be velvety, rich, and mildly spiced.
10. Serve with basmati rice and naan, scattered with fresh cilantro.

Chef Tips

- The longer the marinade, the more tender and flavourful the chicken — overnight is ideal.
- Blending the sauce completely smooth is what gives butter chicken its characteristic texture.
- Add a pinch of dried fenugreek leaves (kasuri methi) at the end for authentic restaurant flavour.